The Problem of Faith and Knowledge

A Historical-Critical Treatise

Problemet om Tro og Viden

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Preface

This work reproduces, in all essential respects unchanged, the content of the lectures I delivered at the University of Copenhagen in the autumn semester of 1867 on the relation between faith and knowledge, between religion, philosophy, and ethics. These lectures encompassed the historical-critical part of the investigation and formed the preparation for an attempt at an independent resolution of the problem under discussion, which will be published in the course of this year.

The historical-critical part of the investigation provides, beyond a brief sketch of the problem's genesis, a detailed critique of those proposed solutions that have acquired a special significance in our literature — among them one, the solution originating with S. Kierkegaard, that was executed with an originality, a seriousness, and a depth that will preserve for it this significance at all times. Through the critique of these proposed solutions — which, in the course of their development and justification, have stood in a sustained polemical or mediating relation to earlier and foreign contributions, and which can partly be regarded as results of previously dominant tendencies, and have partly substantially accomplished the critique of such tendencies — the most significant of the older and contemporary proposals have been illuminated, and in part the complete preconditions have been supplied for a final judgment upon them. This historical critique will then find its supplement in the work that attaches itself to this one.

The present state of the problem in our literature is marked by the conflict between, on the one side, a form of theology that borrows in an eclectic fashion from newer philosophical hybrid formations the weapons with which it will defend the union of faith and knowledge, and, on the other side, the anti-theological-religious standpoint, which, by means of the principled opposition between faith and knowledge, aims to secure the validity of religion and science in their mutual independence and the possibility of their peaceful coexistence within consciousness — while at the same time, by virtue of this same principled opposition, denying theology all right to bear the name of science, a name theology claims for itself by

demanding to be a "science of faith" [*Troesvidenskab*].

The philosophizing theology, which maintains the possibility of appropriating and expressing the content of faith in the form of knowledge, and which therefore not only wishes to claim the name of science for theology but assigns to it, as the concluding form of revelatory science, primacy among the sciences and judicial authority over them, has had as its historical point of departure the speculative system that, through an ambiguous extension of the concept of "religion," brought religion in its specific sense into an identical relation with philosophy, from which it was to be distinguished not by any difference of content, but only by a difference of form. After this ambiguous unity had to be abandoned in the struggles that developed following the emergence of Hegel's philosophy of religion, the theology influenced by philosophy, exchanging the designation of speculation for that of the Christian, nevertheless preserved the tendency toward mediation; but it now rests primarily upon a different philosophical orientation — and in particular upon the system that, by introducing a redoubling into philosophy, creates room for a "free thinking" which borrows from its close relative, the imagination, the "magic cloak" [*Fjederham*] enabling it to soar above the abysses of mystery; and it cautiously inserts a qualification that cuts off even the "higher science's" consequences whenever thought, despite its "freedom," involuntarily comes to follow its own essential laws.

The anti-theological theory, which likewise presupposes Hegelian philosophy, but whose relation to that presupposition is originally negative and polemical, had as its historical incitement also the protest — lodged by a philosophy that presents itself at once as the consequence of and as the opposition to that speculative doctrine of mediation — against the unity of religion and philosophy. The most significant representative of this tendency is Feuerbach — a man whose writings are known only very incompletely and judged only very superficially by those in our literature who have criticized him. Conceiving religion's standpoint as practical in opposition to science's theoretical standpoint, and determining the former ever more sharply through the emphasis on its alogical element, he arrived at the irreconcilable opposition as his view of the relation, and demanded, in the interest of genuine cognition and genuine ethical action, that religion be absorbed into science and ethics. Religion as such was to disappear — as something alogical, as an imperfect transitional stage in the development of the human spirit's self-consciousness — leaving behind only its name in an improper and figurative sense.

In agreement with Feuerbach regarding the opposition, but disagreeing as to its

grounds and its application, S. Kierkegaard draws the distinction between religion and philosophy in religion's interest. The human spirit, which in the restlessness of existence cannot grasp the Eternal in the objective certainty of cognition, and which acknowledges the limits of its own cognition, finds only in the religious relation, in faith, a subjective existential certainty regarding what is its deepest interest; it finds there, and only there, its true reconciliation. The validity of knowledge is not denied, but objective knowledge is bounded to a domain in which the spirit's deepest interests cannot find their satisfaction. Faith and knowledge thus each receive their own territory, and through this, and through knowledge's subordination, the compatibility of both within the same consciousness is to become possible.

This Kierkegaardian conception of the problem of the relation between faith and knowledge has been taken up by Professor R. Nielsen and presented in such a way that some have wished to place him on a par in originality with the theory's originator, attributing to him the resolution of a task of the same creativity as the one Kierkegaard strove to resolve. How little this view is warranted will be demonstrated in this work. It will emerge that the problem has not been advanced by Professor Nielsen; that the form he has given the solution has introduced only uncertainty and vacillation into the decisive determinations; that the attempt at a psychological and metaphysical grounding of the separation of the principle of faith from the principle of knowledge as absolutely heterogeneous with it has failed and leads to irresolvable contradictions; and that the same holds for his grounding of the proposition that the absolutely heterogeneous principles can be united within the same consciousness.

When, then, alongside S. Kierkegaard — the genuine representative of the anti-theological-religious standpoint — such detailed attention is devoted to Professor Nielsen, it is not because the theory has received from him a deeper grounding or a richer development, but because it has through him exchanged the character of an esoteric doctrine for an exoteric one, penetrated into the broad circles of "the cultivated," and in these circles is in the process of changing from a question of knowledge into a question of faith, and of being fixed as dogma by virtue of an unappealable *ipse dixit*.

As representative of the philosophizing theology, Bishop Martensen appears in this work; but since the argument is closely tied to what is given in his writings, the universal, the typical in the standpoint is nowhere lost from view, nor forgotten in favor of the individual. It has not been necessary to give direct consideration to

other theological attempts in our literature.

The ultimate task, whose resolution is prepared through the critique — which immediately can yield only a negative result — is the vindication of a standpoint that has not found expression in our discussions, and that has been advanced elsewhere only in forms that cannot satisfy. This standpoint maintains such an opposition between science — philosophy in particular — and the positive forms of religion, between knowledge and faith understood as revelatory faith, that knowledge and this faith cannot be brought to unity within the same consciousness; — it maintains the impossibility of a genuine and substantial ethics, one that encompasses the whole, real human life, developing on the basis of positive religion with its supernatural law of action; — and it maintains the inner, indissoluble unity between genuine cognition and genuine ethical action, the necessary dependence of the latter upon the former. But while it maintains this opposition, it asserts with equal decisiveness, on the other side — distinguishing the essential determination of the religious from the phenomenal forms of the positive religions, in which it sees only a partial, imperfect, finitizing expression of the former, and thus distinguishing what is religious in the religions from the religions in their historical forms — the inner unity of the religious, the philosophical, and the ethical, and through this inner unity the inner unity of human life: the condition for its true and complete reconciliation, the reconciliation within reality, the reconciliation of undivided human nature with itself in its essential ground. In affirming the essentiality and necessity of the religious relation for the human being, whose self-consciousness is first fully actualized therein, through God-consciousness, and who according to the fundamental relation of its nature has never been and never will be without religion; — in further seeing ethical action and genuine cognition as gaining a higher significance through their unity with the religious fundamental relation; — and in allowing genuine knowledge and genuine ethical action to become an adequate form of actuality for the religious, it conceives this knowledge and this action as containing within themselves a Highest and Unconditioned, in which what is essential in the religions is preserved. This standpoint we designate as *the religiously reconciled humane consciousness.*

It differs from the position occupied by Feuerbach not merely in that its metaphysical fundamental concept is a different one — one upon which a cognition and an action bearing the stamp of ideality and universal validity can be built, and from which the concept of human freedom can be vindicated and a religious relation grounded to the Absolute, with which the human being is in essential unity — but

also in that it combats theology and dogma not only in the interest of ethics and science, but first and foremost in the interest of religion itself, in the interest of the infinity of the religious relation.

It differs from the old Hegelian school's conception of religion's relation to cognition, in that it does not see the religious merely as a form of knowledge, but as the expression of a fundamental relation encompassing the whole of human nature in its concreteness, and in that it does not let the medium of spiritual life be an illusory abstract element of eternity, but reality with its real conditions and limits.

With the anti-theological-religious theory it concurs in its conception of theology's relation to science. Since it rests upon scientific cognition and, in undivided human nature, assigns primacy to cognition, it must be its task to vindicate the clear concept of science and science's autonomy, grounded in its own nature, against equivocations and against attempts, based on equivocations, to subordinate science to the dominion of a foreign, heterogeneous authority. But while there is thus, in an essential point, an agreement between it and that theory, it enters into a decided opposition to the latter when the relation between faith and knowledge, between religion, philosophy, and ethics, is to be determined. This opposition concerns Kierkegaard's conception, with respect to which it will be shown that it undermines the certainty of all cognition and allows the ethical to disappear into an abstract and reality-less religious sphere. But it concerns even more precisely the form in which the theory has been elaborated and presented by Nielsen — a form that Kierkegaard would certainly not recognize as his own. The form in which Nielsen develops the theory leads, despite all the more or less adroit turns that are made in order to avoid this consequence, to an actual dualism in human nature, to a division of the life of the spirit from its very ground by means of the "absolutely heterogeneous" principles, to the inevitable self-dissolution of consciousness; it corrupts the ethical at its root and opens the path to the religious for all that is superstitious and absurd. With the conviction that the absolute heterogeneity Nielsen posits between the principle of knowledge on the one hand and the principles of faith and action on the other is "a misunderstanding that is ruinous for religiosity, morality, and all genuine character development," I have subjected his theory to a thoroughgoing critique, and sought to demonstrate its untenability, its deficient grounding, its self-contradictions, its ruinous consequences.

In publishing this contribution to the investigation of a problem that through the centuries has had, and will continue to have, the most decisive significance

for the human spirit, it is my hope that it may occasion a renewed, serious, and conscientious discussion — a sharp and open conflict between principles. Such a conflict, even if carried on with sharp weapons, can only serve the interest of the cause; and one must therefore hold dear the combatant for whom the cause, and not some egoistic self-regard, is the highest consideration. A firm and deep personal conviction I shall always respect; by sound reasons I shall always be just as open to influence as I intend to be impervious to anything other than these.

Chapter 1

Historical Moments Illuminating the Emergence of the Problem

1.1 The Preparation of the Problem in Antiquity

It is first among the Greeks that a definite approximation to a clarification of the problem of the relation between faith and knowledge comes into view. In the Orient, e.g. in India, one becomes aware, where a thinking relatively independent of religion develops, of the discrepancy between its results and the doctrines of religion, and an opposition forms between a heterodox and an orthodox doctrinal edifice; but the distinctive character of Oriental philosophizing, its lack of thoroughly achieved independence from religious doctrine, of the capacity to develop its content in the form of the concept, and of a clear consciousness of the principle of philosophy, brings it about that no reflection is reached concerning the principled ground of the difference—that is, no consciousness of the essential determination of faith and knowledge. The conscious difference is only the factual difference of content.

In Greece, where the knowing spirit becomes conscious of itself in philosophy, and, in unfolding the content of its knowledge, connects it through a single principle, it can, with this content of knowledge—of whose principle and whose connection with the principle it is conscious—enter into relation with religion as it is given in the forms of popular religion, and the problem is intimated; indeed it even seems, at the close of classical antiquity, to come forward in its decisive form. It will, however, become apparent that even where the question of the relation between the doctrines of philosophy and of religion, and of religion's significance for the spirit's cognition, is most strongly accentuated, one does not get beyond intimations, and that what

prevents this is the specific distinctive character of the Greek spirit.

Already in the earliest period of Greek philosophy we see philosophy standing in a critical-polemical relation to popular religion and its myths. Thus the founder of the Eleatic doctrine of unity, Xenophanes, combats the anthropomorphistic conceptions of the gods in the myths, and his polemic is repeated in other thinkers of that remote time, but without our finding in any of them a genuine reflection on the significance and nature of popular religion. In the culmination period of Greek philosophy, in Plato and Aristotle, the critical relation to the mythical emerges in connection with a clearer reflection on philosophy's position with respect to the myths and cult of popular religion. Here Aristotle's conception in particular becomes significant. What is distinctive for him, as in general for Greek philosophy up to his time, is that philosophical thought, resting and satisfied in itself, passes judgment upon the positively religious from out of itself, without entertaining doubt about thought's authority. In the doctrines of religion Aristotle acknowledges as true only what is confirmed by philosophy; the mythical clothing, on the other hand, he denies truth without hesitation, tracing it back to conscious invention or unconscious anthropomorphizing, and the forms of cult have significance for him only as what is legally valid in the state.

The situation presents itself differently in the post-Aristotelian period, and in this period it passes through two essentially different stages. As Greek philosophy passes beyond its culmination point and becomes conscious of the inner discord that it cannot reconcile, there first appears a greater attentiveness to the religious, in that the relation to it, both the acknowledging and the polemical, acquires a more essential significance for thought that no longer rests securely in itself. We thus see in the Stoics an attempt to rationalize the myth, and we see this attempt bring about a counter-effect of the mythical upon philosophical theory, a counter-effect that becomes evident in the Stoics' theodicy and in their doctrine of divination. On the opposite side we see in the Epicureans a rational opposition to myth, a struggle to free the spirit from the disturbing influence of the fear of the gods, in which Epicurus sees the essence of religion; and in the later Academics, e.g. Carneades, as in the later Skeptics and in the renewal of Cynicism, we find an opposition directed partly against the theological attempts, partly against popular religion.

A new stage in the development of the relation, and one that in this connection is of essential interest, begins around the time when Christianity appears, historically prepared by the development of the Greek and Oriental spirit, in Neo-Pythagoreanism

and in the concluding forms of the older philosophical schools. The more thought was exhausted, the more the spirit theoretically and practically lost its resting point and through skepticism was brought to despair of its own and of reality's truth, the more was truth—the truth of cognition and of action—sought outside the human spirit in the transcendent divine, which through intermediate beings reveals itself to the spirit; and since such divine revelations were seen in the religions, in them a starting point for knowledge was sought. And the relation to revelation—to that occurring through intermediate beings or already given in the religions—was then posited in Neoplatonism as conditioned by religious purifications and by religious practices, in general by a religious life and a religious disposition. Philosophy, which supports itself on this content of revelation and would draw truth from it, is then transformed into theology, and in Neoplatonism, which assigns to philosophy the task of justifying the content of myth, and, in assimilating the idealized myth, of taking the place of the religions as a universal religion, we see within paganism the parallel to Christian-medieval Scholasticism.

At this point one has come as close to posing the problem of the relation between faith and knowledge in its decisive form as can be reached among the Greeks at all. Here there has been reflection on the spirit's—when left to itself—lack of capacity to grasp what is decisive in the last instance in both practical and theoretical respects; philosophy, the unfolding of autonomous thought, has been placed alongside divine revelation, and it has been declared as the result of this juxtaposition that the relation to the Absolute, to absolute truth, cannot be reached through knowledge, but only through the religious life and the religious disposition. Yet the problem in its sharpness does not emerge even here; one reaches only the intimation, and the decisive reason is that the Greek spirit apprehends itself exclusively under the determination of knowledge, that it lets knowledge constitute the essence of the human being—whereby from the outset the possibility is cut off of a principle coordinate with knowledge in its own distinctive character, and still more of a valid opposition to knowledge; but only through the distinction and the opposition can the problem be brought forward and the reconciling unity be recognized.

That the Greek spirit becomes conscious of itself only in the determination of knowledge can be made evident from a double point of view. If we first fix our gaze on Greek ethics, it is immediately striking that in it the concept of virtue becomes the central concept, while the concept of duty recedes. But if we then investigate how virtue is determined, we find it determined as knowledge; and since for the Greeks

virtue expresses the activity of the essence according to its undisturbed nature, the proposition that virtue is knowledge becomes equivalent to the proposition that knowledge is the essential determination of the human being.

To the same result we are led when we consider the way in which the greatest Greek thinkers determine the divine. For Plato the highest is the Idea, more precisely the Idea of the Good, but the Idea is the objectified and hypostatized thought-content, which receives from Plato the determinations *nous* and *phronesis*. In Aristotle the divine is determined as *nous* and more precisely as *noesis noeseos*, which in eternal, uninterrupted energy relates thinkingly to itself and from which all determination of will is excluded. But the essential determination of the divine is the ideal of the human spirit, and it becomes also for these thinkers the highest expression of the essential determination of the human spirit. For Plato the human soul is closely related to the Idea, indissolubly connected with it, and for Aristotle the human spirit in its highest form as *nous poietikos* is in unity with the divine spirit itself, whose essence is exhausted in thought.

How the Greek consciousness, despite the attempts that are made in that direction, does not definitively get beyond the determination of knowledge, becomes apparent when we more closely consider the relation between knowledge and will and between knowledge and faith.

As for the first relation, even where the volitional side of the human spirit is more strongly accentuated—which already occurs in Aristotle, and still more in the last period of Greek philosophy—the distinctive nature of will is never properly recognized, and the attempts to demonstrate the source of this distinctiveness fail, so that will is continually reabsorbed by knowledge. Indeed even where, at the close of Greek philosophy, among the Neoplatonists, it is declared that genuine cognition is conditioned by the right disposition—where, that is, a primacy of will over thought is formally asserted—even there the movement is only a circular movement from knowledge back to knowledge, and knowledge shows itself in the last instance as the sole original. The right disposition, namely—that disposition which turns away from the finite and as such the untrue and vanishing—is immediately determined by a knowledge of this fundamental determination of the finite, such that cognition, in being determined by this disposition, relates only to itself through will, and in its determinateness as concrete cognition has as its actual condition and presupposition the abstract cognition of the fundamental relation. The relation of will to cognition also becomes clear through the abstraction in which will remains: will as will receives

no distinctive positive content; it moves only in the generality of the negative; its highest goal becomes the spirit's ecstatic absorption into the indeterminate infinite.

What holds for the relation of cognition to will holds also for its relation to faith. When we speak of faith, we must make a definite distinction between the concept's application in the earlier period and in a later one. In Plato, *pistis* is placed alongside *doxa* and stands as something lower in opposition to the true form of knowledge; in Aristotle, *pistis* (in the *Rhetoric*) acquires the meaning of means of persuasion. In the meaning of something higher in relation to knowledge, the concept of faith is first used in the concluding period of Greek philosophy. In Philo, who is at least as much a Jewish believer as a Greek thinker, the concept appears in the meaning of the trusting reception and acknowledgment of the content of revelation, and after him the concept is preserved as the concept of that which is higher than knowledge. For Iamblichus the first condition for genuine knowledge of God becomes the faith that nothing is impossible for God. For Proclus, faith designates the immediate relation to the divine unity, in which union with it through the contemplation of its pure being is given. It here forms the opposition to knowledge, which is always determined by the plurality of reflection and which is said to be unable to reach the highest. And yet, despite these determinations, despite the fact that faith, as the higher, is distinguished from knowledge, faith falls under knowledge; the movement here too is only a circular movement from knowledge to knowledge. In the Neoplatonists the indeterminate, infinite unity to which faith relates is precisely nothing other than the negation of determinate knowledge posited through the most extreme abstraction by a knowledge that has come to despair of itself—a negation that exists only through thought, through knowledge, and that in its negativity is determined by it. And in Philo the relation of devotion to the self-revealing divine in its highest and true form becomes the devoted absorption, occurring in ecstasy, into the abstract unity; but this indeterminate unity is the last residuum of abstracting thought, an object of negative knowledge.

The Greek consciousness can thus reach the point of seeing the difference between the content of knowledge unfolded in the system of philosophy and the determinations of religion unfolded in myth and cult, and of becoming conscious of the principle of knowledge; but it cannot, in its monism of knowledge, recognize the principle of religion in its distinctive character, through which it could show itself as something different from or opposed to philosophy and yet valid—just as it cannot, owing to its deficient conception of the movement of the concept, of the nature of spiritual

development, while making knowledge its sole point of view, see the principle of religion as the principle of a subordinate stage in the spirit's teleological development toward philosophical cognition as the spirit's true and adequate form.

1.2 The Emergence of the Problem in Christianity

1.2.1 The New Testament's Pronouncements on the Relation

1.2.2 The Patristic Period's Relation to the Problem

1.2.3 The Development of the Problem in Scholasticism

1.3 The Problem's Resolution in Modern Philosophy and Theology

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Conclusion